

One Choice Changes Everything

CHOOSE YOUR WORK



**Redefine Success and Discover the Work
That Makes You Feel Fully Alive**

DAN DOBOS

Praise for *Choose Your Work*

Choose Your Work is both deeply personal and profoundly universal. It is insightful, provocative, and quietly unsettling. It seamlessly blends research and real-world anecdotes with practical, step-by-step guidance to help you identify what matters most. This is a book for anyone who has ever sensed there must be more — more meaning, more joy, more alignment between who they are and the work they do.

Genia Janover | Award-Winning Former Principal | Bialik College | Former Fellow | Australian College of Educators

Dan Dobos says the scary, quiet thing out loud: how we spend our working lives is a choice. *Choose Your Work* is both a wake-up call and a practical roadmap for anyone ready to make that choice.

Ben Stickland | Co-Founder & CEO | Instamove

This is the kind of book I will go back to regularly. Some self-help books you read once. Others bring value over and over throughout your life. This is the latter.

Teshia Harding

Choose Your Work distills a lifetime of insights and wisdom into a practical guide to help you clarify what matters most.

Jonar Nader | Former IBM Executive | Author of *How to Lose Friends & Infuriate Your Boss*

Chapter Two alone helped me more than therapy has.

Kayla Giles

Choose Your Work is a timely and deeply needed guide for anyone who senses there must be more to work than simply earning a living. In a volatile world that pushes people toward conformity, this book offers a practical and thought-provoking path back to what truly matters.

Mark Bowles | Dean, Tasmanian School of Business and Economics | University of Tasmania

In my work as a psychotherapist, I see how easy it is to lose sight of who you truly are. *Choose Your Work* offers a thoughtful and compelling path back to yourself.

Kirk Fisher | Psychotherapist & Zen Teacher

Honest, raw, and real. *Choose Your Work* was exactly what I needed.

Christy Oshima

Unlike other career change manuals, this is a guide for those searching for fulfilling work that is both optimistic and encouraging.

Helen Praetz | Emeritus Professor and Former Pro Vice-Chancellor | RMIT University

If you know someone graduating college, buy them this book. If a friend just turned 30, buy them this book. Most people stumble into careers that 'kinda work' and there they remain stuck. Don't be like most people. Buy this book.

James Tuckerman | Founder | Anthill Magazine

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**Redefine Success and Discover the Work
That Makes You Feel Fully Alive**

DAN DOBOS

For

My kids: Sebastian & Bella

Dedication

*This book is dedicated to my parents: Marian & Peter
They immigrated from Romania to Australia,
and from humble beginnings,
they built a life for themselves,
showing me that every opportunity we have is
built on the unseen effort and hard work of others.*

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Author website: DanDobos.com

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The Key to Making This Book Work for You

This is not a book to simply read.

If you want to get real value from *Choose Your Work*, don't just read the book. Use it to *pause and reflect*.

At the end of each chapter, you'll find a brief reflection titled *Pause. Reflect. Grow*. In just a few minutes, you'll be able to uncover actionable insights tailored to your situation.

Choosing your work begins with a pause.

Reflect.

Then take action.

That's how change begins.

1

What If My Whole Life Has Been Wrong?

*Why do so many people experience a
deep sense of regret at the end of their lives?*

Ivan Ilych, a legal practitioner revered by his peers, had a frightening thought on his deathbed: *What if my whole life has been wrong?* He had climbed every rung of the professional ladder, conformed to every social expectation, yet still felt an emptiness untouched by his many accomplishments.

What if that were you? What if, lying on your deathbed, you realized that despite following all the rules, you overlooked what mattered most? What if you chose the wrong career? What if you spent your time on things that never really mattered? What if you were skilled at your job, but it never brought you any joy?

It's a terrifying thought that your whole life has been wrong. But what's even more unsettling is that this is not just a hypothetical idea.

Bronnie Ware, a palliative care nurse for many years, documented the regrets shared by patients in the final stage of their lives. The most common regret was: *I wish I'd had the courage to live a life true to myself, not the life others expected of me.*

The insights from Ivan Ilych and Bronnie Ware about living meaningfully remind me of when my dad migrated from Romania to Australia. When his family first arrived, they couldn't afford chairs, so they used fruit boxes from the grocer instead. Even today, at various moments — like when I sit on a comfortable chair — I visualize my dad sitting on a fruit box and my heart swells with emotion. I become almost teary-eyed as I feel my chest flooded with energy, which then envelops my entire body.

This sense of awe and gratitude for being able to live in Australia fills me with determination and focus, reminding me that I won the lottery at birth and that many people are deprived of the same opportunity. It makes me appreciate that each moment is irreplaceable, that I have an obligation to work hard, think hard, and live to my full potential.

My father's story helped me realize how much life has to offer. It made me notice that many people have stable careers, possess reasonable intelligence, and lead respectable lives. They do all the things their culture and families programmed them to do. They honor their commitments, study diligently, adhere to the rules, get to work on time, pay taxes, complete paperwork, raise families, retire, play with their grandchildren, and finally, they die. While this is an entirely valid way to live, a nagging question lingers: Is this all there is?

Despite outward appearances of success, many reach the end of their lives grappling with a profound sense of regret because they never pursued their innermost desires. They got caught up in life's mundane distractions instead of embracing the depth of what life has to offer. While there were many happy occasions, these were experienced without fully comprehending that their deepest aspirations were quietly being overlooked.

It's as if they somehow believed they had an unlimited supply of time, even though the finite nature of life is undeniable. The average person spends 45 years working, which amounts to approximately 90,000 hours. This book urges you to examine your own life so that when you reach its end, you look back without the haunting regret that plagued Ivan Ilych.

This book is for you if you sense there's more to life than the same document, the same spreadsheet, and the same meetings on repeat. If you seek work that resonates with your core, if you desire a life imbued with a deeper meaning, then this book is for you. If you don't address these aspirations, the ensuing restlessness can lead to a life half-lived, untapped potential, and a lingering shadow of what could have been.

This book is for you if you want to stop suffering in comfort and begin living to your full capacity. Let's discover your deepest truth, redefine what success means to you, and begin a fulfilling new chapter in your journey.

I personally confronted these issues when I encountered the book that changed my life.

The Book That Changed My Life

I have always been good at math. In eighth grade, I got 100% on the final exam. I continued to excel in math throughout high school and received many first-class honors in Engineering/Law at the University of Melbourne.

I picked engineering because of my proficiency in math, rather than seeking out what truly excited me. While there were aspects of my studies that I enjoyed, the type of work covered in civil engineering left me uninspired. By overvaluing my math skills, I failed to pursue what really mattered to me. I suffered from the curse of competence.

After graduating from the University of Melbourne, I successfully made it through a grueling six-round interview process at an elite consulting firm. My time in the corporate world taught me a lot about rigor and structure. It also helped me realize that I feel most fulfilled when helping people grow as opposed to focusing solely on commercial outcomes. So at twenty-five, I chose my work for the first time by leaving my corporate job. I began a coaching business to show students an easier way to study.

Each morning, I spent an hour writing, exploring ideas that intrigued me. One day, I decided to write *Choose Your Work* as a gift for my kids because I hoped it would help them cultivate meaningful and fulfilling lives.

I never would have expected that I was writing this book for myself as much as I was writing it for my kids. It was like the book had a mind of its own, working on me while I thought I was working on it. I came to understand that the book that will most impact your life isn't a bestseller recommended on social media; it's the book that you write yourself. It turned out that writing this book was accidentally the greatest gift that I have ever given myself.

Each morning for two years, I blocked out 9 a.m. to noon to work on this project and went to bed every night looking forward to this uninterrupted time. Ordinarily, my phone would constantly distract me. But during these morning sessions, my focus was intense because the work energized me — so much so that at times, I felt waves of energy going down my spine. It felt like I was doing the work that I was meant to be doing.

There were many challenging moments. Sometimes, I got stuck and felt like I had no idea how to progress. Even then, I enjoyed being defeated by the work. I enjoyed dancing with difficulty. I embraced the roller coaster through its ups and downs. I hung on tightly because I could feel in my bones that this work resonated with my true self. It would have been easy to keep running my business as usual, but something deep inside me had already rejected ease and comfort a long time ago. So I kept going, uncertain as to what would come next but completely certain that I was on the right path.

As I became more absorbed in writing, I began to notice a pattern. I would work intensely from 9 a.m. to midday in a state of bliss. Then midday would arrive and I would have to stop. I would feel a sharp pang of sadness as I extricated myself from what I loved doing to deal with the demands of my business. As this pattern repeated itself, I became aware that something was amiss.

As much as I greatly enjoyed working in the business, it had a very particular rhythm. It required intense attention to detail and juggling many moving parts, with each day fragmented into countless short bursts of energy to address the multitude of tasks and people requiring attention.

In contrast, I discovered that writing energizes me due to its singular focus. Writing this book allowed me to immerse myself in a web of ideas and develop a perspective on a neglected topic. As the writing pulled me in with an increasingly strong magnetic force, I came to realize that deep down, there was nothing that I wanted more than to think and write all day. It then dawned on me that, as the author of *Choose Your Work*, it would be unacceptable to ignore this very same principle in my own life.

And so, once again, I chose to pursue the work that called me. While I believed that staying in the business would be more financially rewarding, something deep within compelled me to commit fully to writing. I had always lived well below my means, which meant I could risk hiring someone to take over my role in the business. I faced setbacks recruiting the right person but decided that I would do whatever it took, for however long it took, to move forward with my plan. Eventually, I found someone to replace me.

Was it easy to choose my work? Absolutely not. But without a doubt, it felt right in every cell of my body.

My journey helped me grasp the real difference between a strength and a weakness, which is further explored in *Chapter 8: How to Overcome the Curse of Competence*. Despite ignoring my true strengths, my sheer grit and determination led me to a highly sought-after corporate job and a successful coaching business. But when you choose the work that you are meant to do, your work will light you up. It will capture your attention and give you an immense surge of energy. It will make you feel more powerful, bring you joy and enthusiasm, create an enriching inner journey, and make you feel fully alive.

Choosing your work means pursuing the kind of work that energizes you and brings a deep sense of meaning. This often involves letting go of

others' expectations and embarking on an uncertain yet deeply fulfilling path. But if you choose your work, it becomes a true expression of who you are, not merely a means to an end.

Why We Unknowingly End Up in Unfulfilling Careers

Firstly, we need to examine what we are told about work. We're often told things like, "If it were fun, they wouldn't call it work," and "You work to make money during the week so that you can enjoy the weekend." We're told that work is strenuous effort performed under the watchful eyes of authority. We're told we *have to work* to earn enough money to retire. Really? You're going to endure decades of misery and then what? What happens if you don't like retirement, or worse, if your health quickly deteriorates after you retire?

No. These beliefs about work are both common and incorrect. They are horribly misleading, and this book will attempt to dismantle them one by one.

Since we need to find a way of earning money, some people simply accept the first job they are offered. They don't give it much thought. Others spend more time thinking about their careers. They look for a secure and prestigious job. They like to tell others that they're an "Executive Director at National Bank" or that "I run my own business."

You might feel proud that you've landed a high-profile job or that you own a successful business. You are comforted that others believe you are doing something respectable.

But here's a quieter question that bubbles up beneath the surface: How does the work actually feel day in and day out, when no one's watching? Specifically, does the work give you energy or drain your energy?

At first, it's easy to gloss over this question. On the surface, social approval is comforting and hard to resist. Additionally, there's nothing inherently wrong with seeking security, prestige, or material comfort.

But if these external achievements become your primary focus, a quiet restlessness emerges.

Slowly, almost imperceptibly, you detect an uncomfortable feeling like a pebble in your emotional shoe. It's that unnerving sensation that something just doesn't feel quite right. It's your heart speaking to you, refusing to be misled by any logical argument constructed by your mind. Your heart insists on fulfillment and will keep sending you signals until it feels satisfied. The purpose of the mind is to set the heart free.

When something seems amiss, you can feel it in your gut, which contains approximately 300 million neurons and is often referred to as the second brain. Pay attention to this feeling. These neurons operate independently of your conscious thinking, which means they can sense psychological difficulties in a way that the logical brain cannot comprehend.

What Happens If You Ignore Your Gut Feeling?

It can be difficult to admit to other people that you don't feel good about your work, but you are not alone. Gallup surveys have revealed that 79% (more than three in four people) are disengaged at work.

When you find yourself in this situation, it can be extremely challenging. You may not enjoy the work, but you must earn a living. Your life may look good on the outside — working in a nice office with an impressive title at a reputable company — but on the inside, you feel hollow. It's an unsettling inner journey.

You wake with a sense of angst, not because the day ahead is particularly daunting, but because it feels painfully the same as yesterday. The projects on your desk often don't excite you and sometimes feel like an endless loop of monotony. Many people reach a point where the work that once challenged them now feels more like drudgery. The question is: Do you accept the drudgery and keep plowing forward? If so, to what degree are you selling your freedom for financial compensation?

What dollar value do you place on your freedom?

When you reach this point, something within you starts to change. There's a gradual loss of self-respect from doing work that doesn't feel right. You might experience mood swings and grumpiness, or you may smile and laugh less frequently. Many report feeling understimulated yet overwhelmed.

You might feel flat — your energy drops and your creativity diminishes. You find it hard to focus and easy to procrastinate. Your interest in your craft declines, and you may experience a sinking feeling as you wonder whether you should do something different with your life.

I remember that sinking feeling all too well. While I worked in a corporate job, I felt my spirit was slowly being suffocated. But by working hard, I managed to numb myself to the dissatisfaction and the nagging feeling that I was wasting my potential. Every Sunday night, as I would prepare my clothes for the next day, that angst would creep in — a stark reminder that another week of soul-crushing monotony awaited me.

These psychological problems arise from doing work that you were never meant to do — work that clashes with your true nature. If you fail at a job, there's a clear signal that something needs to change. But what if you succeed? Paradoxically, excelling in a seemingly “good job” that you know isn't right for you poses a greater threat to your well-being because the social pressure to stay in this “good job” quietly breeds discontent. As author Jim Rohn reminds us, “If you are not willing to take a risk on the unusual, you will have to settle for the ordinary.”

With these inner life struggles, it's easy to become addicted to your phone so as to escape your emotional distress. Social media, TV, and video games numb the pain. Unfortunately, they also reduce the quality of your decisions. Poor mental health causes stress, leaving your body fatigued.

For some, electronic distractions will not suffice. You may reach for processed foods and then for something stronger. It might begin with alcohol and quietly spiral to something more destructive.

Given that 79% of people are disengaged at work, when do you think most people die? Studies have found that heart attacks are most common on Monday mornings, right at the start of the work week.

The worst part about dying at 9 a.m. on a Monday morning is the thoughts you have right before your death, knowing that you spiraled down a thoughtless path into a meaningless abyss.

The real trap is that this abyss didn't look like failure. It disguised itself as your success in that “good job,” appearing rosy on the outside with pleasant conversations, fun hobbies, and respect from co-workers at the office. It is so appealing that your willful blindness became a voice of reason, divorcing you from your heart and coaxing you to enjoy the surface pleasures of life.

This was precisely the experience author Laurence Boldt had when he spoke to residents at a nursing home. He was struck by how many expressed regret about “things they always wanted to do with their lives, but hadn't done.”

The worst part was not that they failed to achieve their dreams, but that they never even tried. Many had secretly nurtured ideas — sometimes for thirty or forty years — yet they never even took the first step.

On the other hand, Boldt mentions that there were a few who listened to their heart and lived their dreams. He observed how “they had an energy, a vitality, and a sense of humor that the others lacked... they seemed more at peace with themselves and with the prospect of death.”

When asked if he feared dying, one such man said, “Death is not a problem if you have lived first.” Sadly, Boldt noticed that his unmistakable vibrancy was a “rare exception in a sea of despair.”

Boldt's experience highlights that failure is not the worst outcome. While failure might hurt temporarily, far worse is being permanently shackled by the fear of failure and never pursuing your deepest desires.

This is a wicked spell that you must overcome. Regret stings the most when you have never tried and are left haunted by what might have been possible. When you explore your deepest desires, you win by listening to your intuition and doing your best with what you have, even if you fail to achieve the expected outcome. The experience provides wisdom, helping you to better navigate the future. But if you don't listen to your intuition, if you ignore your deepest desires, it's like taking a sledgehammer to the cockpit of a plane. You are destroying the navigation system, which hampers your ability to embark on your true path.

So How Do You Deal with This Situation?

You can ignore it. I did, for a while, but the confusion kept nagging at me. Know that it's okay to feel unsure. Most people are silently confused.

The moment you reach for your phone as an anesthetic to drown out your feelings is the very moment when you most need to pause. What is the real issue? It's usually not something that a job promotion or a vacation will solve. If you ignore this moment, the discomfort will reappear until it becomes so familiar, you barely even notice it.

So listen to the confusion. Own the confusion. Sit with the tension between your heart and mind. Embrace it like an old friend. Don't feel bad. Many people simply complain and never take action to change their situation. It takes courage to do the difficult work of confronting this challenge.

Consider your situation in light of this peculiar incident. In September 2012, a tour bus driver in southern Iceland stopped near a canyon to give passengers time to explore the surrounding area. The passengers returned, but the driver noticed that one guest was missing. He called the authorities, and when search and rescue arrived, the bus passengers joined in the search. A day later, a passenger realized that she was the missing person! She had changed clothes and the driver didn't recognize her.

Just like the woman who was searching for herself without realizing it, we too can become so absorbed in our pursuit of success that we lose sight of our true selves. You know that you want to be respected by others and to have enough money to live a comfortable life. But is that it?

This book offers you a moment to pause and reflect on what matters most to you. Think of it as a vacation from the rest of your life. You get to stop searching. While you read this book, reduce the notifications on social media so that more of your attention flows inward. By letting go of compulsive activity, you will have more headspace to confront the core issues in your life. When you reemerge into the world, your improved clarity will bring renewed vigor.

Life's hidden expiration dates highlight why clarity matters so much.

Why Life's Hidden Expiration Dates Are So Important

Let's look at the life of a typical person and do some simple math...

- There are 52 weeks in a year.
- Let's be optimistic and assume that medical technology keeps accelerating at its current pace. You look after your health and, as a result, manage to live to 100 years old.
- $100 \times 52 = 5,200$ weeks. If you live to 80, that's 4,160 weeks.

This diagram highlights the Stoic philosophy *memento mori*, which translates from Latin to "Remember you must die." One day, you will not be able to pursue the things that really matter to you. Your time on this planet is limited, and therefore, passively ignoring your unrealized potential is unacceptable.

Since you have a finite number of days left to live, there are only a finite number of times that you will do each activity. At the time of writing, I have eleven-year-old twins. I take them to school every day. It's hard for me to accept, but I know the day will come when I take them to school for the last time. Similarly, there will come a time when I see my good

The Three-Year Mirror

If I were forced to repeat my average day from the past week for the next three years, what is one thing I would change or stop doing?

Duration

Two minutes

You've just read a chapter about people who reached the end of their lives with regret. This reflection is your chance to avoid that scenario. Pause to consider whether your current path aligns with your deepest truth. Be brutally honest with yourself, even if it's uncomfortable. Small moments of self-reflection can illuminate the way forward and help you course-correct before it's too late.

Many find that writing by hand promotes deeper self-reflection and better memory retention. However, if typing or recording your thoughts feels more natural, choose what works best for you. The most important thing is to engage in the reflective process.

Feel free to exceed the suggested duration if you wish. This reflection is intentionally brief because small, consistent changes lead to life-changing results.

Write Your Reflections Here

- ☐ I have noted what I might regret if I don't make any changes to my average day.
 - ☐ I have circled the single most important insight or action to take.

In the Next Chapter...

Sometimes we are so entangled in our struggles that we fail to appreciate the value they offer. But in the next chapter, we'll explore how your greatest challenges may actually harbor hidden insights that can transform your work.

2

The Unexpected Gifts Hidden in Your Struggles

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges so they become pathways for growth.

What Do the Leaning Tower of Pisa, Improvised Jazz, and Japanese Pottery Have in Common?

The Leaning Tower of Pisa was created by accident. A mistake made during its construction in 1173 caused the tower to tilt. In fact, the defective structural design had to be stabilized from a 5.5-degree tilt to a 3.97-degree tilt in the 1990s for safety reasons. Yet this unintentional defect has become one of its most celebrated features, drawing visitors from around the world. The defect created the beauty.

When musicians play improvised jazz, by definition, they do not follow the notes on the score. We delight in the new melodies formed by the deviation from the planned composition.

Imagine a shattered teacup, not discarded, but painstakingly pieced back together, the cracks filled with shimmering gold. This is *kintsugi*, a practice in Japanese pottery that sees beauty in imperfections. Instead of hiding the flaws, they are accentuated, creating a unique and beautiful piece of art.

The Leaning Tower of Pisa, improvised jazz, and the Japanese art of *kintsugi* highlight how there is beauty in the unexpected, the irregular, the interruption of the pattern. You are no different. Your specific challenges are a high-definition image of your authenticity. No one else has experienced your difficulties with the level of detail and clarity that you have. Your challenges contain seeds of brilliance that you can use to create distinctive work.

The challenging experiences that leave you feeling shattered are not meant to be hidden. Just as the *kintsugi* artisan carefully restores each crack, you too can pick up the fragments of your past and begin the process of golden repair.

Just as a jazz musician is valued for their unique melodies, you too will find success by tackling issues connected to your personal struggles. The first step is to recognize that you are not your work.



Figure 2: The practice of *kintsugi* accentuates flaws by filling them with gold.
View and download this photo in full color at:
ChooseYourWorkBook.com/kintsugi

You Are Not Your Work

The most common reaction that people have when they think back to emotionally challenging experiences is, “Oh, I just wasn’t good enough.”

That’s very different from writing an article and wondering, “Is this a high-quality article?” This is a great question to ask because it will help you identify the criteria for high-quality work. By knowing these criteria, you will write a better article.

Observe the difference between “Is this a high-quality article?” and “Am I a good writer?” When you ask the latter question, you might hesitate and lower your self-worth. This leads to a feeling of despair. Instead of facing challenges and giving them your best shot, you get swept up in a mixture of overthinking and insecurity.

So how do we separate the two? Challenge the quality of your work, but never challenge your self-worth. At your core, you are whole. Nothing can diminish your inherent value.

You can further improve the quality of your work by changing “Is this a high-quality article?” to “What could make this article better?” This more specific approach avoids the heightened emotion connected to the vague “This is great” versus “This is terrible.” Your most perceptive insights emerge when you sit behind the article and contemplate both its strengths and weaknesses. Notice how this has everything to do with the article and nothing to do with you.

In the same way that you separate the quality of your work from the quality of yourself, it is equally important to distinguish between what happened in the past and who you are today. You are not your work. You are not your profession. You are not the situations you have encountered. You are something far greater.

In light of this separation, let’s now examine what happens if you fail to confront your past challenges.

The Problem with Ignoring a Challenging Experience

When I was working in the corporate world, I was emotionally disconnected from my work. My initial discomfort wasn't a sharp pain that was strong enough to compel change. Instead, it was more like a dull, recurring ache, the kind that lingers in the background and slowly wears you down. A persistent gray fog, absent of both joy and sadness, settled over my daily lukewarm mediocrity.

Some people suffer their entire lives with this familiar discomfort to the point that they stop noticing it. I eventually realized that when I numbed myself to one feeling, I actually numbed myself to all feelings. By failing to engage with my emotions, I was trapped in a maze of indecision, constantly second-guessing my choices and desires.

When you ignore your feelings, you are more likely to get stuck in unsatisfying work. The only thing worse than doing unsatisfying work is pretending that it's not a problem.

When you notice pain, feel the pain. When you notice joy, feel the joy.

Think back to a time in your past that was both emotionally intense and difficult to navigate. Pause to recall the specific sensations that you remember experiencing. Only by fully feeling the moment can you comprehend its larger significance.

Here is a series of comparisons by psychologist Steven C. Hayes to help you feel an experience more fully. For each comparison, pause long enough to connect it to a challenging experience.

Hold your experience like a delicate flower in your hand.

Embrace your experience like a crying child.

Sit with your experience like you would sit with a person with a serious illness.

Look at your experience like you would look at an incredible painting.

Walk with your experience like you'd walk while carrying a sobbing infant.

Honor your experience like you'd honor a friend by listening carefully even if it was hard.

Inhale your experience the way you would take a deep breath.

Abandon the fight like a soldier putting down the weapon and walking home.

Take in your experience like a glass of pure cold water.

Carry your experience like a picture in your wallet.

In business, I've faced several setbacks. These comparisons have been invaluable in helping me to peacefully reconnect with a challenging experience, reframe it, and gain clarity. They have helped me realize that compassion is not just important for the sake of being kind to others. We are all grappling with our own internal struggles. By recognizing that most people are doing the best they can with what they have, compassion helps you to see more clearly.

Now that you have felt your challenging experience more fully, the next step is to let it go.

The Rock Concert

We're now going to transform your challenging experience into something new by doing an activity together.

Take a moment to revisit the experience and concentrate on a specific feeling it evokes. It could be anxiety — the tension or unease from a perceived threat. Maybe it's sadness — a heaviness or sorrow weighing on your mind. You might feel anger — a sense of resentment or irritation toward a situation or a certain person. Perhaps it's guilt — the feeling of responsibility for something that went wrong. Or maybe it's disappointment — the letdown when expectations are not met. Whichever emotion you notice, allow yourself to feel it fully for ten seconds.

Imagine you're standing in front of the stage at a rock concert, close enough to touch the performers. You don't just hear the music; you feel it reverberating through every bone in your body. The pounding bass

echoes in your chest as the scent of smoke and sweat mingles in the air around you. Strobe lights flash intensely, painting the crowd in rapid, fleeting bursts of color.

This rock concert is a metaphor for your challenging experience — intense, overwhelming, and transformative. Don't engage with any words or thoughts. Just surrender to the raw sensation of the moment, letting it wash over you and carry you away on a tide of pure emotion.

Now imagine you're in a helicopter above the concert. With binoculars, you zoom in and see yourself immersed deeply in the rock concert, immersed in that painful experience. But when you take away the binoculars, you see everyone else at the concert. You can see the band, the lights, and thousands of people. You become a witness to the experience. Instead of being swept up by the emotion, you sit back in your seat and relax behind it, looking at the scene from a distance.

You stay with it. You don't comment. You simply observe it. You see it in its entirety, and then... you let it go. The helicopter departs from the scene. You look back toward the concert as it gets smaller and smaller and then disappears.

You are no longer there. The concert is now in the past. You are here in the present. It's a prior experience. It's not you. And as you let it go:

- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...
- Breathe in the difficulty for four seconds... and breathe out for six seconds and let it go...

And you notice that you now feel a little bit lighter.

Look at the fragments of your experience. Were they broken, chipped, shattered? Take a breath. Imagine you're a *kintsugi* master, picking up the

pieces of this experience. As you allow gold to flow through the cracks, what was once pain is now transformed into beauty.

The experience is still part of you, but it no longer defines you. It transforms into something beautiful and strong that will guide you in the next stage of your journey. The transformation not only enriches your life, but by letting go of the past, you are able to make space for the future. With a lighter load, you are much better positioned to discover the work that you are meant to do.

Who Am I Now?

Too often we criticize our prior actions — even those from several years ago — to the point that we let them distort our present experience. Yet the cells in our bodies are replaced daily. In about ninety days, most of your roughly 30 trillion cells will transform into new ones. You are not only a more mature and experienced person with evolved thinking patterns; you are also a biologically different person from who you were several years ago.

If you were exactly the same person you were many years ago, you might be angry with yourself because you may repeat the same behavior. But you are a different person now. Even if you wanted to, replicating the past would be almost impossible. Yes, breathe a huge sigh of relief because the past is over and done with. You will still face challenges, and even if elements of the past repeat, knowing the future will differ from the past should bring you some joy. As your capacity to respond grows, you will have new, richer, and more interesting experiences than ever before.

After even a mildly intense experience, it can be interesting to ponder: Who am I now? How have I evolved? The answer: it's a mystery. You never quite know exactly who you are. All that you can be sure of is that you have grown. Maturity is about accepting the flux of life and recognizing that failure is baked into the process of growth.

How Your Challenges Help You Grow

Rabbi Harold Kushner reflected on the death of his son, who tragically passed away from a rare genetic disease at just fourteen years old. He said:

I'm a more sensitive person, a more effective pastor, a more sympathetic counselor because of Aaron's life and death than I would've been without it. And I would give up all those gains in a second if I could have my son back. If I could choose, I would forego all of the spiritual growth and depth, which has come my way because of our experience. But I cannot choose.

He not only accepted what happened, but he learned from it, grew from it, and moved forward. That's what we want to do now. We must take this difficult experience and move beyond acceptance. We must use it as a springboard to grow.

Viktor Frankl, an Austrian psychiatrist, personifies such growth. While trapped in the atrocities of a concentration camp, he articulated a profound truth with exceptional clarity:

We who lived in concentration camps can remember the men who walked through the huts comforting others, giving away their last piece of bread. They may have been few in number, but they offer sufficient proof that everything can be taken from a person but one thing: the last of the human freedoms — to choose one's attitude in any given set of circumstances, to choose one's own way.

To help survive these atrocious conditions, Frankl wrote notes about his work and hid them in his coat. He was dedicated to his craft for his entire lifetime. He knew what he stood for. For Frankl, psychiatry wasn't merely a profession. It was a calling. He knew that he was sent to do this work. So he did it, and he did it exceptionally well. Indeed, after being freed from the concentration camp, Frankl wrote his groundbreaking book *Man's Search for Meaning* in just nine days.

Sixty-nine years after Viktor Frankl wrote his book, Anthony Ray Hinton was released from prison in another part of the world. After

being framed by the police, Hinton was wrongfully imprisoned for a full thirty years, spending almost his entire time on death row. His Alabama prison cell was infested with rats and cockroaches. He was given scarcely enough food to survive. He spent barely fifteen minutes a day out of his cell. He heard the shrieks of other cellmates being executed in the electric chair. Then the odor of death filled the air, leaving a grim reminder of the execution that occurred just meters away.

How would you respond to these living conditions? While most would lose their composure, Hinton responded with a level of character that we can only hope to emulate, an inimitable ability to transcend the horrific conditions he endured and the gross injustice so mercilessly inflicted upon him. Recounting his experiences, this great man echoed the wisdom of Viktor Frankl, stating:

Despair was a choice. Hatred was a choice. Anger was a choice. I still had choices and that knowledge rocked me... I could choose to give up or to hang on. Hope was a choice. Faith was a choice. And more than anything, love was a choice.

While falsely imprisoned, Hinton established a book club for fellow inmates. After his release, instead of retreating into a private life, Hinton did the opposite. He devoted himself to public speaking, offering hope to those confronted by injustice. His quiet strength and powerful message resonated globally as he harnessed the transformative power of suffering to uplift the lives of others. Hinton's lost years behind bars fueled his public speaking with an intense energy that deeply impacted the lives of those who heard him speak.

Kushner, Frankl, and Hinton each accomplished something very rare. They mastered the art of emotional judo. Judo is the art of using your opponent's weight to redirect their force instead of confronting it head-on. Similarly, emotional judo harnesses negative emotions so that, instead of letting them weaken you, their weight elevates you to a higher level of consciousness. These men transcended their situations by choosing hope over despair, offering us a profound example of how to live.

These experiences highlight that while there will always be challenges, the inescapable question is: Are you willing to use the force of these difficulties to create a transformation? These experiences are valuable because they give you depth, mold your character, and improve the quality of your thinking. As Camus put it, “In the depths of winter, I finally learned that within me there lay an invincible summer.”

These men also teach us how struggles can become the driving force behind work that is personally fulfilling and valuable to others. Just as Frankl further excelled in psychology and Hinton devoted himself to advocating for justice, you too can establish a new path illuminated by your challenging experiences.

Hopefully, you haven’t endured a fraction of the atrocities faced by Kushner, Frankl, or Hinton. However, if you hadn’t struggled at all, you wouldn’t appreciate the contrast between your past and present. More importantly, you can use these past struggles as seeds to cultivate something beautiful. The pain loses its sting when you absorb its lesson.

This is just the first stage of your journey. Your past challenges are here to help you navigate the next stage.

As the Zen proverb states, *Who knows what is good or bad luck?* It is easy to fall into the trap of believing that getting what you want will create the best experience for you. But more often, it is in the thick of challenging experiences that you uncover hidden gems. It is in these experiences that you break barriers, change perceptions, and create memories that leave an indelible mark on your life.

How to Channel Your Emotions to Build Something Remarkable

When John Wilson was twelve years old, his chemistry class participated in a routine experiment involving boiling water. Unfortunately, a lab assistant had mislabeled a bottle, so instead of boiling water, John boiled a much more reactive substance. The substance caused the container to

explode, shattering many glass bottles. Tragically, John Wilson left that science experiment completely blind.

Most people would be devastated, sink into depression, and lose hope. But John just got on with it. He quickly learned to read Braille, became an accomplished rower, swimmer, and actor, and studied law at Oxford University.

At age twenty-seven, he found himself in Africa. He noticed that blindness was far more prevalent there than in the Western world due to a lack of medical resources. He reflected on how his blindness resulted from an accident and grew angry that millions of others were blind simply due to insufficient resources. Something had to be done, so John established several organizations that helped prevent blindness in tens of millions of people.

If Sir John Wilson could turn his deeply unfortunate experience into a project that helped millions of people, what might be buried in your challenging experience, waiting to be uncovered? Observe the mixture of anger, frustration, and compassion that John felt and how he channeled that energy into something useful. Now, tap into the emotions that your challenges elicit. Feel the emotion deeply. Just as the *kintsugi* artist fills the cracks with gold, use the energy that comes from your challenges to create something that matters to you. Choose the work that fills the cracks with gold.

The Value of Writing About Challenges

When you write about your challenges, you release ideas that were taxing your mind. You expel negative emotions from your body. What once burdened your mind and strained your body now exists in its own place, on its own sheet of paper, separate from you. Now that you are no longer gripped by this narrow emotional focus, you can broaden your gaze and consider related thoughts. This is how you develop perspective.

The more you write, the more your writing reveals to you that you are not your thoughts. You are not your experiences. Your thoughts and

experiences are separate from you because you are something far greater. You grow to discover that emotions stemming from difficult experiences have a perverse allure, leading you to replay them over and over in your head. But when you write about the experience and let it go, you uncover its hidden value as you progress to the next stage of your growth.

The Hidden Gift

Reflecting on the challenging experience visualized in this chapter:

1. What is the strongest emotion that surfaces when I think about my challenging experience? (e.g., fear, gratitude, relief, frustration)
2. As I sit with this emotion, what emerges as truly important? What have I learned about myself from this experience, and how have I grown from it?
3. Based on what I have learned, what is a project that I would love to pursue?

Duration

Two minutes per question

Feel free to extend this reflection if you're finding it valuable. Writing about challenges can be emotional, so be gentle with yourself. Through this reflection, you're beginning the process of transforming your challenges into sources of strength and insight.

Like the *kintsugi* master carefully mending cracks with gold, you're finding beauty and clarity in your struggles. Let this new perspective guide your choice of work. Perhaps a past experience revealed a hidden strength or highlighted a problem you're now driven to solve. Connect the dots between past and present to envision a project that feels less like a job and more like a calling.

Since this activity is more emotional than others, many find that writing by hand is the best way to complete it.

Write Your Reflections Here

- ☐ I have reflected on a challenging experience and used it to identify a project that I would love to pursue.

☐ From my reflections, I have identified the most important insight or action to take. Circle it.

In the Next Chapter...

Embracing your struggles sets the stage for profound transformation. You know what else holds you back? Suffering in comfort. Next, we will examine how to overcome this and redefine what success means to you.

3

Don't Confuse Success with Suffering in Comfort

Why your focus on comfort is ruining your life and obscuring the true metrics of success.

The Mysterious Nature of Time

When you witness a child's birth, admire an extraordinary view, laugh heartily with friends, or savor a delicious meal, it's unlikely that you think about your financial situation. Why is that? Such raw human experiences often remind us that some of life's richest moments have nothing to do with money.

What do you think of at times like these? Actually, you don't think. Your experience exceeds your ability to think. Time stands still. You are in the here and now. You are so tightly integrated with the experience that you transcend the mundane distractions that characterize ordinary living. Your capacity to fully participate in each moment is perhaps your most precious gift.

I'm sure that you've had occasions at work when you were so engrossed in a project that you lost track of time, just like when you gazed at a beautiful view. But sadly, for many of us, most of the workday is not an enriching experience. In fact, it's barely an experience at all.

About the Author

DAN DOBOS is an entrepreneur who has spent over 21 years running a coaching business and working with more than 50,000 people. He began writing this book as a gift for his children, but as he wrote it, the book worked on him too. He came to realize that the book that will most impact your life is the one you write yourself. To find out more, visit DanDobos.com

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When you look back at your life, will you be satisfied?
Or will you have regrets?

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•

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